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WE HEREBY PROMISE... (Clockwise from above) The BJP, Congress and AAP release their poll manifestos

GUJARAT/ POLL PROMISES

WOOING THE YOUNG URBANITE

By Jumana Shah in Ahmedabad

The aspirational middle-class voter has replaced the poor villager as the main target of political messaging in Gujarat. About 45 per cent of its voters are under 40; it's also India's second-most urbanised state, with 44.45 per cent of the population living in cities. Some 58 of its 182 seats are now urban—the BJP won 44 of them in 2017—and another 35-40 have graduated to semi-urban status. All this is showing in the political discourse: wooing the middle class is thus an imperative for both BJP and AAP (the Congress reverting to its old KHAM caste alliance means it has little contribution to the poll narrative). The mockery of '*revdi* culture' notwithstanding, the sops this time are mainly reserved for the young and unemployed across categories. Nothing illustrates the tilt better than a conspicuous absence in the BJP's slew of promises. As sociologist Ghanshyam Shah points out, "Farmers are not even being talked about."

BJP'S PROMISES

- Making Gujarat a $1 trillion economy in five years—which would entail a four-time jump from its current size, Rs 19.4 lakh crore
- Hosting the 2036 Olympics in Ahmedabad
- Four Gujarat institutes of technology on the lines of the IITs
- Two AIIMS-level institutions
- Attracting Rs 5 lakh crore foreign investment, making Gujarat India's defence and aviation manufacturing hub
- Setting up two seafood parks (one each in south Gujarat and Saurashtra), building India's first Blue Economy Industrial Corridor

FREEBIES FREE-FOR-ALL

Education
BJP: Free, quality education to all female students from KG to PG
Congress: Free education for marginalised communities in govt facilities—KG to PG
AAP: Free education for all in government schools

Healthcare
BJP: Doubling free healthcare cover from Rs 5 lakh to Rs 10 lakh under Aayushman Bharat plus free diagnostics in public hospitals and empanelled laboratories for EWS households
Congress: A Rs 10 lakh health insurance and Rs 5 lakh accident insurance network in a public healthcare map covering the whole state
AAP: Free healthcare in government facilities

Cooking gas
BJP: Two free LPG cylinders in a year for EWS households
Congress: Subsidised cylinder costing Rs 500
AAP: Silent

Housing
BJP: Ensuring every citizen in Gujarat has a pucca house, 100 per cent implementation of Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana
Congress: Housing for all landless and homeless families on priority

Food
BJP: 1 litre of edible oil four times a year, 1 kg subsidised chana per month through PDS

Electricity
BJP (in Modi's speech, not manifesto): Earn from generating